TEAM LEADER ESSENTIALS

Team Leader Essentials — Day 4: Handling Underperformance and Conflict

Study guide · Self-study

Day 4: Handling Underperformance and Conflict

How to Use This Guide

This is Day 4 of Team Leader Essentials. You have spent three days shifting from top performer to leader, setting expectations, running a daily huddle, and coaching with the Question Ladder. Today you deal with the part of the role most new leaders avoid: underperformance and conflict.

Read one section at a time. Write your answers to the Reflection prompts before you move on. The "What Would You Say?" exercises come before the model answers on purpose: write your version first, then compare. The model answers are examples, not scripts. Keep the principle, use your own words.

You will need a real situation from your team. Think of one team member whose performance is slipping, and one friction between two people that you have been putting off. Keep both private by leaving out names where you write things down, and use them in the exercises.

Do the practice out loud. Conflict conversations are delivered under pressure, and words you have only read do not survive that pressure.

Today's Objectives (KASU)

Knowledge: Know why conflict handled early costs less than conflict ignored, why people separate themselves from the problem, and how to open a difficult conversation with A.R.T.

Attitude: Treat raising a problem as a service to the team, not as disloyalty or drama. Decide that your silence is a decision.

Skill: Run a structured underperformance conversation, mediate a clash between two team members using A.R.T., and turn a fight about people into an agreement about rules.

Upskill: Lead one real underperformance or conflict conversation end to end this week, from the private first talk to the follow-up check, and log what you agreed.

What Underperformance Really Is

Underperformance rarely arrives as a clear problem. It arrives as "she's a bit off lately", as a missed call-back rate nobody mentions, as tasks that stall at the same stage every month. A new leader's instinct is to wait for it to become undeniable, then deal with it in one heavy conversation. That is backwards.

The reason sits in how people read silence. A team member who is struggling and hears nothing concludes one of two things: that you have not noticed, or that you have noticed and do not care. Both lower trust. Meanwhile the rest of the team watches you not act, and draws a third conclusion: standards here are optional. Bad behavior that goes unaddressed spreads because it looks permitted.

So underperformance is not only the person's problem. It is information about something in the system: unclear expectations, a skill gap, a personal situation, a rule that is missing, or a role the person was never set up to succeed in. Your job is to find out which one before you decide what to do about it.

Two pitfalls to avoid. First, the fix-it reflex: you take the work back and do it yourself, the habit from Day 1 that undoes delegation. Second, the verdict conversation: you open with your conclusion ("your numbers are bad") and the person defends instead of talks. You want them talking, because the cause is in their head, not yours.

The psychology behind this: people protect their sense of competence. A conversation that threatens it produces justification, blame shifting, or withdrawal. A conversation that treats performance as a shared problem to solve keeps that sense intact, and keeps the person able to hear you.

Reflection: Write down the team member you thought of. Now write what you would say in the first thirty seconds of the conversation. Does it open with your verdict, or with a question? Keep this line; you will rewrite it later.

A.R.T., MEDJAY's own framework, for Difficult Conversations

A.R.T. is MEDJAY's own framework, developed by Steven Saad, for handling concerns, resistance and complaints in any difficult conversation. It has exactly 3 steps, always used together, in this order.

Acknowledge: Label the person's feeling in plain words, with no "but" after it. "You're frustrated that this came up in a group message." "This feels like I'm questioning how hard you work." No "but", because "but" deletes the sentence before it and turns the label into a setup for your defense. Naming a feeling calms it, which is why the acknowledgement comes first, not last. Lieberman and colleagues found that putting a feeling into words lowers its intensity.

Reframe: Shift the decision criterion from the visible cost to the cost of staying where you are. The visible cost in a performance talk is discomfort, embarrassment, or the feeling of being judged. The reframe moves the question to what happens if nothing changes: the customer who waits too long for an answer, the teammate who keeps covering, the next month that looks the same. Do not defend your right to raise it. Change what the conversation is about.

Transition: Ask a calibrated how or what question that hands the next move to the person. "What would help you hit the call-back target in the next two weeks?" "How would you like to handle the handoff from here?" Never a yes/no question in this step. A yes/no ask ("Can we agree to improve?") invites a polite yes that costs nothing and changes nothing. Asking a calibrated how or what question is a technique from Voss and Raz.

Why the sequence works: the person arrives expecting to be judged, and their attention is on defending themselves. A genuine acknowledgement removes the thing they were defending. The reframe makes the current situation costly rather than the conversation uncomfortable. The calibrated question restores their agency, so the outcome is something they built, not something you imposed. People carry out plans they helped make.

A.R.T. is for concerns and resistance. It is not a way to avoid consequences where a formal process applies; it is how you keep the person thinking and talking inside that process. For the step that needs to be a decision with a date, use a genuine choice: "Would Thursday or Friday work for you to start on the revised list?"

Reflection: Take the conversation you wrote in the last section. Write one Acknowledge line for it, then say it aloud. Did you want to add a "but"? Where?

The Five-Step Conversation for Underperformance

This is the structure you run, one to one, private, and scheduled rather than ambushed.

1. Name the gap, with facts. Use SBI — Situation, Behavior, Impact, the model from Day 2 — in one or two sentences. "In the last three weeks, four quotes went out without a follow-up call. Two customers called us asking for an answer." No adjectives about the person.

2. Ask, then listen. "What's happening on your side?" Then stop talking. You may hear a skill problem, a workload problem, a rule problem, or something personal. Whatever you hear, acknowledge it before you respond.

3. Agree one change. One. Not five. A specific behavior, a specific standard, a specific start date. Write it down in the person's words. Keep the Commitment and consistency principle in mind: a person who states a specific plan out loud is far more likely to follow it than one who nodded at yours.

4. Agree the check-in. A date within two weeks, in the calendar before you both leave the conversation. Say what you will look at together.

5. Follow through. Show up to the check-in on time, and praise the change you see. If nothing changed, the next conversation is shorter and firmer, precisely because the first one was clear.

A word on the anger you may meet. If the person protests that this is unfair, do not argue the facts line by line. Run A.R.T.: acknowledge the sense of unfairness, reframe to what staying the same costs them, transition with a calibrated question. You will practice that in the role-play below.

> **NOTES**
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> The most common mistake at step 2 is filling silence with your own answer. Count to five in your head. Let them speak.

Conflict Between Team Members

Two people clash over who owns an account, who covers the phones at lunch, or who dropped a handoff. Most leaders hear it as a personality problem. It usually is not. Ask what rule was missing and the "personality clash" often shrinks to a gap in the process.

First, separate the person from the problem. "Jake is lazy" suggests only blame. "Lunch coverage isn't clear" suggests a fix. Train yourself to hear every complaint in both forms, then work on the right-hand one.

Second, talk to each person privately before you ever bring them together. This matters for two reasons. Privately, people tell you the version they will never say in front of the other person. And when you later sit them down, you are not hearing the story for the first time and being played against the other side. Bring them together only after both have been heard alone.

Third, when you do bring them together, lead with a shared goal. "You both want this customer to stay." That sentence changes the room from me-against-you to both-of-us-against-the-problem.

Fourth, agree specifics: who does what, from when, and how the handoff works. A rule that lives only in the conversation will be forgotten. A rule with names and dates survives.

Fifth, follow up. A check-in within two weeks, separate or together. Conflict agreements fail quietly, so go and look.

Watch for the shortcut: picking a side in the huddle to end the noise quickly. It feels decisive. What it actually teaches the team is that the loudest voice wins, that you decide before you know the facts, and that losing means going silent and skipping handoffs. One argument ends; a bigger problem starts.

Why people fight over rules they don't have: they want fairness, and without a rule each person builds their own version. A clear rule does not just solve the dispute; it removes the reason for it to recur.

Reflection: Name the last clash in your team. In one line, write the person version, then the problem version. Which version would produce a fix you could agree this week?

When the Customer Is Angry

The same principles apply on the customer side, with a different pressure: the customer is angry at the situation, not at you, even when it sounds personal. They cannot hear a solution until they feel heard.

Let them finish. Do not interrupt and do not defend. Defending early confirms their view that you care more about your side than theirs.

Then acknowledge what they are likely thinking — name the worst of it, sincerely, before they say it. "You probably feel like we don't care about your order. I'd feel the same in your position." This works because the customer is braced for excuses. When you name the fear yourself, there is nothing left to fight, and their attention can move. It only works if it is real. Said as a technique, it makes things worse.

Then fix first: options, not explanations. And follow up to confirm the fix held.

A.R.T. works here too: acknowledge the feeling, reframe from who is to blame to what gets the customer whole, transition with a calibrated question like "What would a good outcome look like for you today?" Then deliver.

Practice example: A customer calls furious because a delivery arrived two days late and they lost half a day of work. You say: "You're right to be annoyed — you lost time because of us." Then: "The thing that matters now is getting the rest of your order to you so your work isn't held up again." Then: "What would a good outcome look like for you on this one?" Notice that you never claimed to know what the delay cost them.

Apply It in Your Role

"As a team leader": raise friction early and privately, turn fights into missing rules, and handle angry customers with the sequence above rather than with apologies and promises.

"With your own performance": you were a strong individual performer, and your record still feels like your safety net. Use it. Say "I got this wrong last week" in front of the team, and you make it safe for them to do the same.

"With your manager": conflicts with other departments, or rules that need approval, go upward. Report patterns in customer complaints, not just single incidents — a pattern is what gets a rule changed.

> **NOTES**
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> When you escalate, bring the rule you propose, not only the problem. Managers act on proposals.

What Would You Say?

Write your answer to each of the three situations before you read the model answers. Keep them general and pattern-level; do not use a real name.

1. A team member has missed their follow-up call target three weeks running. You open the conversation. What are your first three sentences?

2. Two team members both claim the same account, and one has started skipping handoffs. What do you do first, and what do you say when you bring them together?

3. A customer is shouting on the phone that your team cost them a full day of work. You pick up the call. What do you say first?

Key Takeaways

- Conflict handled early is cheaper than conflict ignored. Your silence is a decision.
- Solve the problem, not the person. Most "personality clashes" are missing rules.
- Talk to each side privately before you bring them together.
- A.R.T., MEDJAY's own framework, runs Acknowledge, Reframe, Transition — with no "but" and no yes/no question at the end.
- With angry customers: lower the temperature first, solve second.

Quiz

Answer each question. Choose one option per question, and write your reason next to it before you check the notes.

1. A team member's numbers have slipped for three weeks. What is the best opening move?

   A. Send an email listing the missed targets so they have it in writing.

   B. Wait one more month in case it corrects itself.

   C. Book a private conversation, name the gap with facts, then ask what is happening.

   D. Raise it in the daily huddle so the whole team learns from it.

2. In A.R.T., what happens in the Reframe step?

   A. You restate the person's concern in your own words.

   B. You shift the decision criterion from the visible cost to the cost of staying the same.

   C. You offer a concession to show good faith.

   D. You ask a calibrated how or what question.

3. Two team members are in conflict over shared accounts. You have heard both privately. What should you do next?

   A. Decide who is right and announce it to end the noise.

   B. Tell them to sort it out between themselves as adults.

   C. Bring them together, name a shared goal, and agree specifics with a follow-up date.

   D. Move the account to a third person.

4. A customer is angry on the phone. Your first priority is to:

   A. Explain what went wrong on your side so they understand.

   B. Offer a concession immediately to calm them down.

   C. Let them finish and acknowledge what they are likely thinking.

   D. Ask them to put the complaint in writing.

5. A team member is underperforming and you run the conversation. Which ending is strongest?

   A. "So, can we agree you'll do better?" — a yes/no commitment.

   B. One specific change, a start date, and a check-in booked in the calendar.

   C. A general expectation to "take it up a level" over the quarter.

   D. Five changes at once so nothing is missed.

Upskill Challenge

Complete this on the job before Day 5, on your own.

Choose one real situation from your team: a performance gap or a friction between two team members. Run it using today's steps — private first, then A.R.T. in the conversation, then one specific change with a date and a check-in.

Keep a short log:

Situation (no names): ____

What I heard privately: ____

My Acknowledge line: ____

My Reframe line: ____

My Transition question: ____

The one change we agreed: ____

The check-in date: ____

Result at check-in: ____

Then reflect in writing: which step was hardest, and what will you do differently in the next difficult conversation?

If you do not lead a team yet, pick a past conflict or performance gap you saw at work, write how you would run it step by step, and ask your manager or a team leader to review it with you.

> **NOTES**
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> Keep the log factual and short. Leave out anything personal that does not belong in a work record.

Model Answers

These are examples, not scripts. What matters is the principle behind each one.

1. "I want to talk about the follow-up calls. Over the last three weeks the target was met on about half of them, and two customers called us asking for an answer. What's happening on your side?" Why it works: facts, not adjectives; then a question, then silence. The person hears a problem, not a verdict.

2. First, I talk to each of them alone — the account facts from one, the handoff story from the other. Then together: "You both want this customer to stay with us. The real problem is that we have no rule for shared accounts." Then A.R.T. for the resistance: "This has felt unfair on both sides." (Acknowledge) "What we can change today is the rule, not who was right last month." (Reframe) "Who builds the relationship from here, and how do we share the first order? What would make that work for each of you?" (Transition) Then specifics and a two-week check-in.

3. "You're right to be angry — a lost day is real money." Then name the fear: "You probably feel like we don't care about your job. I'd feel the same." Then fix first: give two concrete options with times. Close with "What would a good outcome look like for you today?" Why it works: temperature down, then options, then the customer's own words for what fixing it means.

- Quiz answers:
- 1. C. Facts plus a question keeps the person talking; a public naming makes them defend, and waiting lets the standard look optional.
- 2. B. Reframe moves the question to the cost of inaction; restating is Acknowledge and the calibrated question is Transition.
- 3. C. Private first, then together with a shared goal and specifics; picking a side ends one fight and creates a bigger one.

- 4. C. An angry customer cannot hear a solution until they feel heard; explaining or conceding early confirms their fear.
- 5. B. One specific change with a date and a scheduled check-in is the agreement people actually keep.

> **NOTES**
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> Notice that none of these ends in a yes/no ask. Each hands the next move to the person with a how or what question, or a real choice with a date.

References

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